

1. Folklore as Narrative Logic

Research → Reinterpretation → Symbolic Systems → Player Perception

The project was already built around a specific regional setting when I joined development. Sardinian folklore offered a rich body of myths and figures that naturally support psychological tension. The challenge was avoiding superficial representation, treating local tradition as atmosphere rather than as narrative logic.

The process began with identifying a specific mythological figure whose traditional role was passive and cosmological, an arbiter of fate rather than an active presence. The reinterpretation shifted that figure from indifference to motivation: rather than asking what the entity does, the central question became why it would be angry.

That question became the connective tissue between folklore, setting and social themes. The answer involved a specific history of human intervention, an attempt to extract and exploit the entity's power, that had left both material traces in the environment and a personal wound that predates the player's arrival. Hostility, in this context, is not arbitrary. It is the consequence of grief and violation.

This approach served several functions simultaneously. The antagonist's behavior remains grounded in mythological logic while gaining psychological coherence. The history of human intervention connects directly to the broader social themes of the project: extraction, exploitation, the relationship between outside forces and local identity. And the personal dimension transforms the entity from a creature into a character, making its presence feel motivated rather than mechanical.

2. Landscape as Narrative Material

Space Exploration → Historical Memory → Environmental Meaning

The setting is an archaeological park, a space that by its nature already carries accumulated meaning. Different groups had occupied and transformed the same territory across millennia, each leaving visible traces and contributing to the identity of the place.

This layering became a structural narrative principle rather than background detail. The presence of ancient communities, colonial influences, modern administrative forces and temporary visitors like tourists, researchers, workers, created a space where multiple histories coexist and occasionally conflict. Each group arrived with different intentions. Each left something behind.

The contemporary antagonistic force in the story follows the same pattern: an organisation operating within the park under an administrative guise, whose actual agenda involves the site's deeper history. Their presence adds a modern layer to an already stratified environment, connecting archaeological memory to current exploitation and making the park itself a record of repeated intervention.

Designing narrative around this structure meant treating locations as documents. Spaces were expected to suggest that something had happened there long before the player's arrival, through architecture, objects, and the relationship between ancient and recent traces, without requiring explicit exposition.

The archaeological context also supported a specific emotional register: the feeling of moving through a place that has absorbed and outlasted everything that passed through it.

In practice, this approach informed specific puzzle design. Certain gameplay elements were built around the intersection of multiple historical layers: objects or inscriptions that had passed through different hands across centuries, each group reinterpreting what the previous one had left behind. Solving a puzzle in this context means reading a history of contact, negotiation and appropriation, not just decoding a mechanism. The archaeological setting justified this structure naturally: the park is itself a place where meanings have been repeatedly reassigned.

3. Local Identity and Social Themes

Local Territory → Social Tension → Human Conflict

The regional setting carries a specific historical weight that informed the narrative direction as development evolved. The territory has a long and documented relationship with external intervention (economic, industrial and cultural) in which outside forces have repeatedly extracted value without returning benefit to the local community. This is not abstract history. It remains a present tension in the social and political identity of the place.

Rather than introducing these themes as explicit commentary, the intention was integrating them as underlying forces shaping character motivation and world logic.

The primary human antagonist embodies this tension directly. His agenda involves exploiting a resource embedded in the local territory, but his stated motivation is liberation: using that same extraction to dismantle the structure responsible for it. He is aware of the historical pattern he is replicating. Whether that awareness makes his actions defensible is left unresolved.

This ambiguity was intentional. The social themes of the project were never intended to function as a message. They exist as persistent background pressure, visible in the setting, legible in character behavior, but never formally addressed. The player is not offered a resolution because the territory itself has not been offered one.

4. Character Perspective and Emotional Engagement

Vulnerability → Empathy → Tension → Relief

Within a strongly linear experience with intentionally limited player agency, immersion could not rely on choice or control. Engagement was approached through emotional proximity instead – building complicity between player and protagonist through recognition rather than empowerment.

The protagonist was written as an ordinary person whose reactions to threat mirror familiar human responses: uncertainty, hesitation, fear. The intention was allowing the player to identify with vulnerability rather than overcome it.

This shaped the reward structure of the experience. Tension was designed around a persistent feeling of pursuit and exposure – the player is not expected to feel stronger than the surrounding danger, but increasingly aware of it. Relief therefore becomes the primary emotional payoff: escaping a threat, reaching temporary safety, simply surviving. Small outcomes that carry weight precisely because control was never assumed.